

Subject Positions, High Absolutives, and Austronesian Voice

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Abstract: This paper documents and analyzes the fine syntax of subjecthood in Mandar, a verb-initial ergative language of Sulawesi (Austronesian). It shows that the absolutive DP systematically raises to the juncture between the VP and the middle field, redeeming a central intuition of much work on High Absolutive Syntax (Aldridge, 2004; Coon *et al.*, 2014), in a step of typically covert A-movement masked by the usually rigid word order of VSO. Leveraging a class of nominals that always move overtly, it then shows that the absolutive DP must typically raise even farther into the middle field—and then documents a breakdown in this feeding relationship that yields evidence for expletive insertion in both positions that attract the absolutive DP. It thus mounts an argument that in Mandar the absolutive DP must behave like a subject in the classical generative sense (Guilfoyle *et al.*, 1992): it is raised through a series of A-positions by the formal requirements of functional heads in a series of interactions that culminate in the assignment of the highest structural Case. The Austronesian voice system of the language, on this view, then emerges from the layered interaction of two distinct systems: a regular middle field syntax of subjecthood and a *voiceP*-level syntax that defines a low subject position and guides the assignment of Case.

Keywords:

Subjecthood, Ergativity, Austronesian, Expletives, Covert A-Movement, Sulawesi

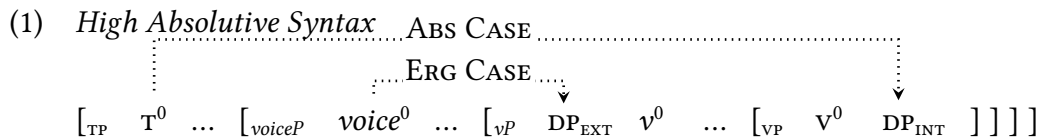
1 Introduction

The notion of subjecthood comes down to Minimalism with a particular theoretical shape. The traditional conceptualization, familiar from Relational Grammar, took the notion to be a syntactic primitive associated with a cross-linguistically stable set of properties. The Standard Theory, in contrast, proposed a redefinition in terms of position: subjects occupied a dedicated space in the part of the clause that fell between the extended VP and CP, and from this position their properties flowed. The work that has followed in this tradition, in turn, has come to decompose that network of subject properties and link them, piece by piece, to a network of interacting and interlocking relationships established between a single DP and the functional heads of the extended TP (McCloskey, 1997).

In the framework that emerges from these parts, the notion of subject holds no formal status of its own—but it is still possible to provide a consistent cross-linguistic definition of what a subject must be. Syntactic derivation is now standardly understood to be driven by the need to satisfy the formal requirements of nominal arguments and functional heads, and the principle requirement that nominal arguments carry into the derivation is the need for abstract Case (Vergnaud, 1977). As this need pushes them to form relationships with the functional heads along the clausal spine, they are then subjected to the independent caprices of those heads—forcing, among other things, the steps of movement driven by ATTRACT (Chomsky, 2001). On this view, the syntax of subjecthood emerges from a particular theory of clause structure and Case: one on which the functional heads of the extended VP assign Case to all of their arguments but one, forcing that DP to receive Case from the heads of the the extended TP—or the middle field. It is in this context that the properties of subjects emerge: the DPs licensed in this way are drawn up to higher positions by the idiosyncratic and cross-linguistically variant properties of those heads (Cardinaletti, 2004); they often pass through strings of higher positions as a result (Bobaljik & Jonas, 1996; Shlonsky, 2000; Cable, 2012; Zyman, 2018); and they are subjected to finer requirements—like the need to be definite (Diesing & Jelinek, 1995)—in the same way.

One of the crowning achievements of this paradigm emerges in the realm of ergativity. Ergative systems have long been recognized to raise challenges for earlier theories of subjecthood, and this is because they often force the traditional properties of subjects to come apart (Schachter 1976; Keenan 1976; Van Valin Jr 1981; Manning 1996; see also Svenonius 2002). Some of these properties, like reflexive binding, consistently suggest structural prominence for the ergative DP (Anderson 1976; Brodtkin & Royer 2024). But in

many systems of this type, a second set of properties—bound up with the systems of case-marking and ϕ -agreement (Bok-Bennema, 1991; Tada, 1993), scope (Bittner, 1987, 1994), pronominal coreference (Kroeger, 1993; Brodtkin, 2022; Royer, 2023), and variable binding (Richards, 2000; Pearson, 2005)—strictly fall to the absolutive DP instead. The natural way to understand these systems is first put forward by Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992 in a discussion of Western Austronesian languages couched in non-ergative terms. Building from the VP-internal subject hypothesis (Fukui & Speas, 1986; Koopman & Sportiche, 1988), Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992 argue that ergative DPs strictly originate in the highest thematic position in the extended VP—the position from which their apparent subject properties flow. The distribution of higher subject properties, however, follows from a second fact: the functional structure of the extended VP can assign Case to the transitive external argument, rendering it ergative, but not to the internal argument—leaving it Caseless in that domain (see also Bok-Bennema 1991; Bittner & Hale 1996a,b; Ershova 2019). The result is a clausal architecture that shows what Coon *et al.* 2014 term *High Absolutive Syntax*: one on which the absolutive argument is forced to receive Case from the functional heads of the extended TP and is thus exposed it to the higher network of systems that deliver the middle field properties of subjecthood—often even raising it into that layer of the clause.



The theoretical elegance and explanatory force of this analysis has led to its adoption in many systems of this type: in Inuit (Bok-Bennema, 1991; Bittner & Hale, 1996a,b), Mayan (Coon *et al.*, 2014; Royer, 2023), Tupian (Storto, 1999), Salishan (Wiltschko, 2006), Tsimshianic (Brown, 2016), Circassian (Ershova, 2019), and Austronesian (Aldridge, 2004; Brodtkin, 2022)—where it is also often adopted and framed in the traditional (non-ergative) descriptive terminology (Guilfoyle *et al.*, 1992; Erlewine, 2018; Erlewine & Lim, 2023; Ting, 2023). But there are a number of puzzles that continue to haunt this connection from TP-level subjecthood to the syntax of High Absolutive DPs, and foremost among these are two:

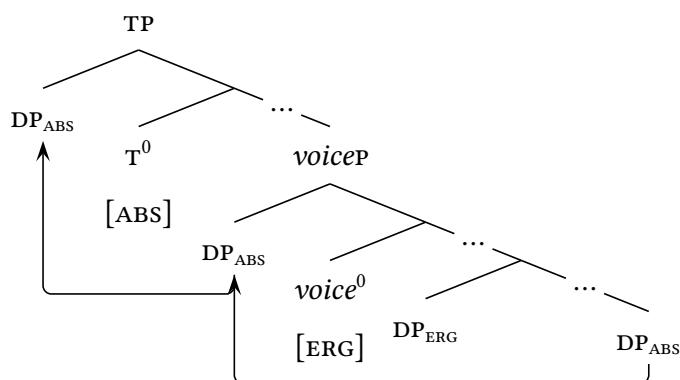
ONE: to what extent do absolutive arguments genuinely interact with the functional structure of the middle field? There is by now a large literature to show that there are many systems where absolutive arguments are Case-licensed by heads in the extended VP even where they bear an unmarked morphological case (often syncretic with nominative, as in Warlpiri: Legate 2006) or control ϕ -agreement on τ^0 (as in Hindi-Urdu, seen especially in

the arena of long-distance agreement: [Bhatt 2005](#); [Bhatt & Keine 2017](#)). It is thus essential to understand the syntax of absolutive DPs in a careful and case-by-case way—and build from there to a fine typology of interactions between absolutive DPs and the middle field.

Two: to what extent do absolutive arguments genuinely raise out of the extended VP? The best-studied cases of High Absolutive syntax emerge in systems that show verb-initial order, and as a result, it is commonly assumed that High Absolutive arguments raise no farther than the edge of the extended VP in both Austronesian ([Aldridge, 2004](#); [Erlewine, 2018](#); [Erlewine & Lim, 2023](#)) and Mayan ([Coon et al., 2014](#); [Royer, 2023](#)). This stance would seem to separate High Absolutive DPs from nominative subjects, which often raise overtly into the middle field, and in language-internal and typological perspectives, it forces the question of whether absolutive DPs interact with that layer of the clause in the same way.

In the face of these puzzles, the task of this paper is to work out the syntax of the absolutive DP in Mandar, a verb-initial Austronesian language of Central Indonesia. Our specific goal will be to develop and defend the analysis in (2): one on which the absolutive DP covertly raises to a low subject position in the *voiceP* and then to a high subject position in the middle field. The path that leads us to this view will provide new linear evidence that high absolutive DPs often raise through the edge of the clause-internal phase ([Aldridge, 2004](#)) and ultimately move into the middle field ([Guilfoyle et al., 1992](#))—and redeem, in that way, the intuition that the absolutive DP is a subject in the classical generative sense.

(2) *Mandar: Rough Clausal Syntax*



The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. Section 2 introduces Mandar and lays out its basic clausal syntax. Section 3 shows that the absolutive DP raises covertly to a low subject position and Section 4 shows that it also raises to a high subject position, leveraging a class of nominals whose movement is always overt. Section 5 shows that the feeding relationship between the two subject positions is able to break down and that each position can force the insertion of expletives along the way. Section 6 then concludes.

2 Background

Mandar is an Austronesian language spoken by 400,000 people in the Indonesian province of West Sulawesi. It belongs to the South Sulawesi subfamily of Malayo-Polynesian (Esser, 1938; Mills, 1975; Grimes & Grimes, 1987) and its closest relatives have been described in a growing body of English-language work (Friberg, 1991, 1996; Strømme, 1994; Matti, 1994; Valkama, 1995a,b; Jukes, 2006; Lee, 2008; Kaufman, 2008; Laskowske, 2016; Finer, 1994, 1997, 1998, 1999; Béjar, 1999; Finer & Basri, 2020). The language has been the subject of several descriptive studies in Indonesian (Pelenkahu *et al.*, 1983; Sikki *et al.*, 1987; Muthalib & Sangi, 1991) as well as two works on its syntax in English: on the nature of its voice system (Brodkin, 2022) and the structure of the VP (Brodkin, 2025b). This paper describes the standard variety of the language, spoken on the coast between the cities of Polewali and Majene (Grimes & Grimes, 1987); its results emerge from long-term research with a single speaker, Jupri Talib, with whom I have been working since 2018.¹

Mandar is a verb-initial language that typically requires nominal arguments to surface between the verb and final adjuncts to the VP. Within this space, arguments take a rigid and consistent order: using terms that avoid reference to abstract Case, the EXTERNAL ARGUMENT (EXT) must precede the INTERNAL ARGUMENT (INT) and in ditransitives, the INT must precede the APPLIED ARGUMENT (GOAL), yielding an order that I will refer to as VSOd. The language shows no morphological case but has an ergative-absolutive system of agreement: transitive verbs agree with the external argument, while second-position clitics agree with the absolutive argument. These properties are shown in example (3).

(3) *The Mandar Clause*

Na-alli-ang	i	[_{EXT} iKaco’]	[_{INT} iGary]	[_{GOAL} iCicci’]	dionging.
3ERG-buy-APPL	3ABS	NAME	NAME	NAME	yesterday

‘Kacho’ bought Gary (a cat) for Chichi’ yesterday.’

2.1 The Shape of the Clause

To understand the rough syntax of the VP, it will be useful to start with the morphology of transitivity. Beneath the ergative prefixes that mark transitive and ditransitive verbs,

¹GLOSSING: ABS: absolutive, ANTIP: antipassive, APPL: applicative, ERG: ergative, GEN: genitive; PASS: passive; 1SG/2SG: first-/second-person singular. ORTHOGRAPHY: <c, ng, ’>: /tʃ, ŋ, ʔ/.

many transitive verbs host an additional suffix *-í* that is only realized at the right edge of a high-level prosodic domain (the intonational phrase: **Brodkin To Appear**). The following examples show its distribution: it appears after the verb *napangino* ‘play’ when final in its clause (4a), but not when the verb is followed by overt material in that domain (4b).

(4) *Mandar Verbs: Morphological Complexity*

- a. {_ℓ Byasa i na-pangino-i }
usually 3ABS 3ERG-play-TRANSITIVE
‘They usually play it.’
- b. {_ℓ Byasa i na-pangino-____ do panginoang o }
usually 3ABS 3ERG-play-TRANSITIVE that game there
‘They usually play that game there.’

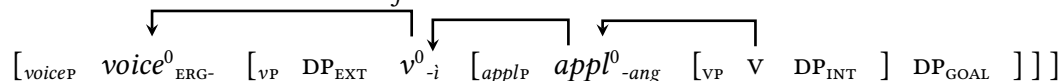
In the same vein, there are several types of DP-DP ditransitives in Mandar, and all of these are built with postverbal applicative suffixes. The most common of these is *-ang* (5).

(5) *The Applicative Suffix*

- Na-alli-**ang** i iKaco’ lo’diang iCicci’.
3ERG-buy-APPL 3ABS NAME ring NAME
‘Kacho’ bought Chichi’ a ring.’

I take these three morphemes to spell out a string of heads in the extended VP: *-ang* sits in a low applicative head *appl*⁰ (Pylkkänen 2008), the transitivity suffix *-i* sits in *v*⁰, the head that introduces the EXT (Collins 2005; Merchant 2013), and the ergative prefixes sit in *voice*⁰. We can then leverage this higher structure to derive the word order of the language by appeal to head-movement—and more specifically, a process of morphological amalgamation (Harizanov & Gribanova, 2019) that carries the Mandar verb to the edge of the *voiceP*. The result is a relatively familiar path to the linear order vso (McCloskey 1991).

(6) *VSO Order: Head-Movement of the Verb*



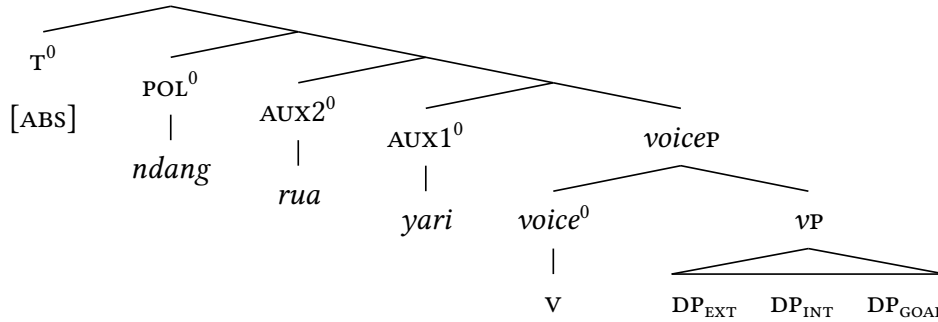
In the space above the Mandar verb sit a closed class of rigidly-ordered auxiliaries that mark distinctions of polarity and aspect (Brodkin, 2025a). Some of these elements are shown in example (7): the realis negator *ndang*, the experiential perfect *rua*, and the completive *yari*. In the clauses that contain these elements, absolutive agreement strictly follows the highest; otherwise, it follows the verb (thus its characterization as a second-position clitic across the subfamily: Strømme 1994; Friberg 1996; Finer 1999; Béjar 1999).

(7) *The System of Auxiliaries*

Ndang i rua yari na-baca.
 not 3ABS once DID 3ERG-read
 ‘She never DID read it.’

[Brodkin 2025a](#) argues that the auxiliaries spell out functional heads in the middlefield that sit just beneath the head that hosts absolutive agreement. Setting aside the exact mechanisms that position this agreement, the result is the rough syntax in (8)—one that has since been substantiated in the language with a range of evidence from the domains of predicate clefting, *voiceP*-ellipsis, and the prosody of the extended VP ([Brodkin, 2025b](#)).

(8) *Mandar Clause Structure*



2.2 The Voice System

With this much in place, we can now lay out the central alternations that make up the Austronesian system of *voice*. Mandar has a series of verbal affixes that surface in complementary distribution with the ergative prefixes, and the alternations among them interact in complex ways with many systems of the syntax. For instance, there are several passive voices that are built with the prefixes *di-* (9a), *ti-*, and *ka-* (all forcing suppression of the EXT). There is also an antipassive construction that is built with the prefix *mang-* (9b).

(9) *The Mandar Voice System*

- a. **Di-**issang di carita-nna de kapping e?
 PASS-know JUST.3ABS story-3GEN this village here
 ‘Are the stories of this village known?’ [Friberg & Jerniati 2000, 207](#)
- b. Byasa i **mam-** baca iKaco’ buku diting o.
 usually 3ABS ANTIP-read NAME book there there
 ‘Kacho’ usually reads books over there.’

The antipassive corresponds to a construction known in the Austronesian tradition as the “Agent Voice” (Kroeger 1993; Aldridge 2004; Paul & Travis 2006); in this terminology, it contrasts with the “Patient Voice” (the transitive) and the “Locative Voice” (the ditransitive). In Mandar, the antipassive does not force visible demotion of the INT and GOAL, but it does require both arguments to be indefinite and allows each to be freely dropped. The nature of this voice is disputed in many other languages of the region, and the ensuing debate has led a strand of the literature to propose that the morphology of voice must sit in c^0 (Chen, 2017) or τ^0 (Rackowski, 2002; Rackowski & Richards, 2005; Hsieh, 2020). But in Mandar it is clear that it must sit in a string of heads in the *voiceP*: both because of the position of the verb (which follows middle-field auxiliaries) and because the voice alternations influence argument structure (often introducing or suppressing arguments)—and this is the position adopted by the mainstream literature on the languages of the region (Aldridge, 2004; Levin, 2015; Nomoto, 2015; Erlewine, 2018; Nie, 2020; Ting, 2023).

With this much in place, we can now see how the voice system interacts with the higher syntax of absolutive agreement. Many patterns converge to suggest that the absolutive agreement enclitics sit high in the clause: beyond their second-position behavior, for instance, they show a pattern of allomorphy conditioned by c^0 . This second fact is shown in example (10): beneath the irrealis subordinator *anna*’, absolutive agreement surfaces in a distinct paradigm of suffixes on c^0 . This pattern suggests that absolutive agreement must sit close to c^0 in the syntax—and as such, Brodtkin 2022 places it in τ^0 .

(10) *Absolutive Agreement: Allomorphy Conditioned by C*

Bulang, indoi a’ mai, **anna’-u** mala ma’issangi alawe-u.
 moon shine.on 1ABS me that-1ABS.IRREALIS can know self-1GEN

‘Moon, shine on me, that I might know myself.’ Bulang, by Sulkep Liaco

This analytical step opens up a central link to the syntax of finiteness. With one important exception laid out in Section 5, absolutive agreement appears in every finite Mandar clause. In the same vein, it is absent from the reduced complement clauses that lack the functional structure of the middle field, like the complements of control verbs (11).

(11) *Absolutive Agreement: Absent from Non-Finite Environments*

Batabata **a’** [_{polP} di-ita ____/***a’** marondong].
 reluctant 1ABS PASS-see 1ABS tomorrow

‘I’m reluctant ____ to be seen tomorrow.’

We can now draw a connection to the syntax of nominal licensing: the network of syntactic systems that converge to determine where nominals can and cannot appear. In the non-finite constructions that lack absolutive agreement, it is generally possible to introduce an EXT whenever the verb hosts ergative agreement: in example (12), for instance, it is possible for an EXT to surface within the non-finite complement of *batabata* ‘reluctant.’ In that same space, however, it is ungrammatical to introduce an INT.

(12) *Constructions without Absolutive Agreement: No Overt Absolutive DPs*

Batabata a' yau [_{polP} na-pelambi'i ____ [_{EXT} **kindo'-u**] [_{INT} (***yau**)]].
 reluctant 1ABS 1SG 3ERG-visit mom-1GEN 1SG
 ‘I’m reluctant ____ to be visited by my mom.’

Brodkin 2022 thus proposes that the system of absolutive agreement endows its targets with abstract Case (on a par with ϕ -agreement more broadly: Raposo 1987). This analytical step, in turn, opens up a second layer to the system of Austronesian voice. In clauses built around transitive verbs, absolutive agreement targets the INT. When the verb is ditransitive, however, the same type of agreement must target the GOAL (13a)—and when the verb is antipassive, it must target the EXT (13b). The result is an exact mirror to the relationship between voice and the distribution of the morphologically unmarked case in the languages of the Philippines and Taiwan (Payne 1982; De Guzman 1988; Gerdts 1988; Aldridge 2004; Liao 2004; Chang 2011; and in Proto-Austronesian: Ross 2006; Blust 2015): the voice of the verb, in our terms, determines the identity of the absolutive DP.

(13) *Absolutive Agreement: Changes Targets with Voice*

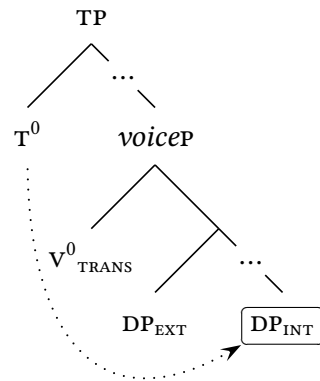
- a. Na-beng-ang a' [_{EXT} iKaco'] [_{INT} buku] [_{GOAL} *pro*] dionging.
 3ERG-give-APPL 1ABS NAME book 1SG yesterday
 ‘Kacho’ gave me the book yesterday.’
- b. Mam-baca a' [_{EXT} **yau**] [_{INT} buku] digena'.
 ANTIP-read 1ABS 1SG book earlier
 ‘I was reading a book earlier.’

This connection sets up a natural perspective on the clause structure of the language that is grounded in both the regional literature on Austronesian and the wider theory of ergativity. This is one that posits two separate and interacting layers of structure: a higher system of *agreement*, operating in the middle field to assign abstract absolutive Case, and a lower system of *voice*, operating in the *voiceP* to determine the identity of the target DP.

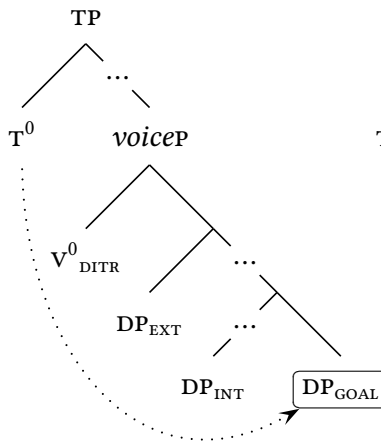
In the transitive *voice*s of the language, this lower system conspires to force the source of absolutive Case to make contact with the INT (14a); in the *voice*s that host ditransitive and antipassive verbs, it works to ensure that T^0 will target the GOAL (14b) and EXT (14c). In the South Sulawesi subfamily, this is the type of syntax established by earlier work on Selayarese (Finer, 1997, 1999; Béjar, 1999); across the wider region, it has been put forward for Tagalog, Cebuano, Malay, Indonesian, and Malagasy by Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992 (avoiding the specific terminology of ergativity) and since developed by much further work.

(14) *Two Layers to the Mandar Clause*

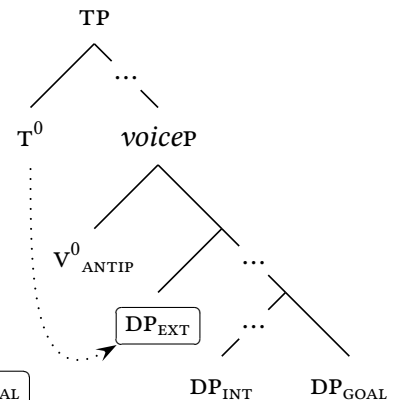
a. *Transitive Voice*



b. *Ditransitive Voice*



c. *Antipassive Voice*



The central challenge that emerges from this backdrop, then, is one of a familiar shape. Restricting our attention to Mandar, the system of absolutive agreement seems to play a role similar to that of subject agreement in a language like English: it reaches down from the middle field to target a single nominal argument in the *voice*P. Its particular interaction with the system of voice, in turn, is familiar from the wide class of ergative languages where the identity of the absolutive argument is determined by alternations in voice. The task of the sections that follow, then, is to understand the fine syntax beneath this interaction—with an eye toward resolving the three foundational questions below.

(15) *Guiding Questions of the Investigation*

- What are the systems that license contact between the absolutive DP and T^0 ?
- How are these bound up with the Mandar-internal syntax of ergativity/voice?
- How might the ultimate shape of this system be brought to bear on the wider theories of subjecthood and Austronesian voice?

3 The Low Subject Position

Our investigation thus begins from the link from absolutive agreement to the syntax of subjecthood, and here we can start from the facts of linear order. When we control for the occurrence of rightward scrambling, Mandarin requires postverbal arguments to surface in the rigid order of $S > O > D$ no matter the facts of case: when the verb is transitive (16a), ditransitive (16b), or antipassive (16c). In the general case, then, the absolutive argument does not visibly move to a consistent and high linear position—establishing a parallel between Mandarin and Tagalog (Rackowski, 2002), many other languages of the Philippines (Reid & Liao, 2004), and all the languages of South Sulawesi (Friberg, 1996; Strømme, 1994; Matti, 1994; Valkama, 1995b; Finer, 1999; Béjar, 1999; Jukes, 2006; Laskowske, 2016).

(16) *Verb-Initial Clauses: VSOD Order*

- a. Na-alli i [EXT iKaco'] [INT itim bunga].
 3ERG-buy 3ABS NAME that flower
 'Kacho' bought those flowers.'
- b. Na-alli-ang i [EXT iKaco'] [INT itim bunga] [GOAL iCicci'].
 3ERG-buy-APPL 3ABS NAME that flower NAME
 'Kacho' bought those flowers for Chichi'.
- c. Ma'-alli-ang i [EXT iKaco'] [INT bunga] [GOAL towa-towaine].
 ANTIP-buy-APPL 3ABS NAME flower girls
 'Kacho' buys flowers for girls.'

The question that emerges, then, is whether there is any dedicated step of movement that raises the absolutive DP at all –or whether it might simply stay low in the syntax and have its features passed up to T^0 in any of several ways (Butt, 1995; Bhatt, 2005; Legate, 2005). The task of this section is thus to make a case for covert A-movement of the absolutive DP: first reviewing a series of arguments from Brodtkin 2022 and then building a new case that it must move into a dedicated low subject position at the edge of the *voiceP*.

3.1 High Absolutive Syntax

This natural place to begin is with a series of asymmetries in pronominal coreference and variable binding that are relatively familiar across the region. The relevant asymmetries in Mandarin have been documented by Brodtkin 2022, and they trace parallel restrictions in Tagalog (Kroeger, 1993; Richards, 2000) and Malagasy (Pearson, 2005). Their initial force

will be to suggest that the grammar of Mandarin enforces two constraints, corresponding to Conditions B and C of the Binding Theory (Chomsky, 1981; Reinhart, 1983), which must be formulated—in Mandarin at least—through reference to c-command alone (cf. Barker 2012; Bruening 2014). With this in place, they will then lead to a secondary result: the absolutive argument must raise to an A-position above all other arguments in the clause.

3.1.1 Condition C

Mandarin is a language that requires unstressed third-person singular pronouns to be null. These null pronouns, however, induce a familiar constraint: they cannot corefer with R-expressions that sit within their c-command domains. The following example illustrates: a pronominal EXT cannot be coindexed with an R-expression in a lower PP.

(17) Mandarin: Condition C

Sicaka i [EXT *pro*] [PP sola nyawa-na kanne'-na iAli].
 convene 3ABS he with soul-3GEN grandfather-3GEN NAME
 'He_{*i,j} convened with the ghost of Ali_i's grandfather.'

This restriction operates in a consistent and familiar way between non-absolutive DPS. In ditransitives, for instance, neither the EXT nor the INT are absolutive, and in this context, a pronominal EXT cannot be coindexed with an R-expression in the INT (18).

(18) Condition C: Ergative EXT > Accusative INT

Na-kiring-ang a' [EXT *pro*] [INT buku-na iAli].
 3ERG-send-APPL 1ABS he book-3GEN NAME
 'He_{*i,j} sent me Ali_i's books.'

This restriction is also resolutely insensitive to the facts of linear order. In the ditransitive construction, then, it is acceptable for the INT to be a null pronoun coindexed with an R-expression in the following GOAL: corresponding to the fact that, on our analysis of Mandarin clause structure, the INT does not c-command the GOAL within the *voiceP*.

(19) Condition C: Accusative INT < Absolutive GOAL

U-kiring-ang i [INT *pro*] [GOAL kindo'-na iAli] digena'.
 1ERG-send-APPL 3ABS him mom-3GEN NAME earlier
 'I sent him_{i,j} to Ali_i's mom.'

These facts suggest the operation of the following constraint: without regard to the facts of linear order, null pronouns cannot c-command coreferential R-expressions.

With this much in place, we can turn to absolutive DPs. When the INT is absolutive, it behaves differently: it gains the ability to contain R-expressions coindexed with the EXT.

(20) *Condition C: Absolutive INT > Ergative EXT*

Na-waca i [EXT *pro*] [INT buku-na iAli] dionging.
 3ERG-read 3ABS he book-3GEN NAME yesterday
 ‘He_{ij} read Ali_i’s book yesterday.’

In ditransitive clauses where the GOAL is absolutive, it acquires the same type of binding privilege. It is grammatical, then, for the ditransitive GOAL to contain an R-expression coindexed with the EXT, as if it raised out of the c-command domain of that DP (21).

(21) *Condition C: Absolutive GOAL > Ergative EXT*

Na-kiring-ang i [EXT *pro*] [INT buku] [GOAL sola-na iAli] dionging.
 3ERG-send-APPL 3ABS he book friend-3GEN NAME yesterday
 ‘He_{ij} sent Ali_i’s friends the book yesterday.’

3.1.2 Variable Binding

The same exact asymmetries emerge in the system of variable binding. Mandar has a universal quantifier *nasang* “every” that is forced to subextract from its associates and raise to cluster with absolutive agreement in finite clauses (Brodkin, 2025c). This step of movement is shown in the two transitive clauses below: *nasang* follows its associate in the control complement in (22a), but it raises to follow the verb in the finite clause in (22b).

(22) *Universal Quantification: Nasang “Every”*

- a. Batabata a’ [POLP na-pittule’i [EXT dospeng-u **nasang**] manini.
 reluctant 1ABS 3ERG-interrogate advisor-1GEN every later
 ‘I’m reluctant to be interrogated by every one of my advisors later.’
- b. Na-pittule’i **nasang** a’ [EXT dospeng-u ____] digena’.
 3ERG-interrogate every 1ABS advisor-1GEN earlier
 ‘Every one of my advisors interrogated me earlier.’

The movement of *nasang* “every” does not affect the patterns of variable binding that are allowed in the language. The factor that is relevant, rather, is c-command: it is impossible for a pronoun to be bound by an *every*-associate that sits in its c-command domain. The following examples illustrate: when *every* originates within a low PP, it cannot bind into the EXT (23a), but when it originates in the EXT, it can bind into this type of PP (23b).

(23) *Mandar: Variable Binding Requires Underlying C-Command*

- a. Sicaka **nasang** i [EXT sanaeke-na *pro*] [PP sola kama' ____].
 speak every 3ABS kid-3GEN his with dad
 'His_{*ij} kid spoke with every_i father.'
- b. Sicaka **nasang** i [EXT sanaeke ____] [PP sola kama'-na *pro*].
 speak every 3ABS kid with dad-3GEN his
 'Every_i kid spoke with his_{ij} father.'

When we turn to the patterns of variable binding that emerge between non-absolutive DPS, then, we find the same pattern that we saw with Condition C. Without regard to the facts of linear order, a quantified and non-absolutive INT cannot bind into the arguments that sit above it: neither the preceding EXT (24a) nor the following GOAL (24b).

(24) *Variable Binding: Accusative INT < Preceding EXT/ Following GOAL*

- a. Na-kiring-ang **nasang** a' [EXT panulis-na *pro*] [INT buku ____].
 3ERG-send-APPL every 1ABS author-3GEN its book
 'Its_{*ij} author sent me every_i book.'
- b. U-kiring-ang **nasang** i [INT buku ____] [GOAL pengedit-na *pro*].
 1ERG-send-APPL every 3ABS book editor-3GEN its
 'I sent every_i book to its_{*ij} editor.'

These restrictions suggests the presence of a very similar constraint in this domain: with no regard to the linear order of arguments or the quantifier *nasang* "every," pronouns cannot be bound by *every*-associates that sit within their c-command domains in Mandarin.

With this in place, we can now turn to the behavior of absolutive DPS. When the INT is absolutive, as in the transitive clause in (25a), it gains the ability to bind into the EXT. When the GOAL is absolutive, in the same way, it gains the ability to do so as well (25b).

(25) *Variable Binding: Absolutive INT/ GOAL > Ergative EXT*

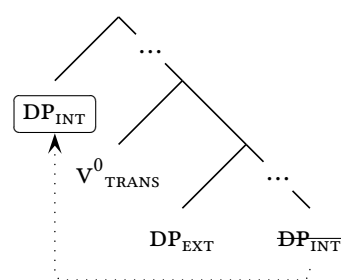
- a. Na-waca **nasang** i [EXT panulis-na *pro*] [INT buku ____].
 3ERG-read every 3ABS author-3GEN its book
 'Its_{ij} author read every_i book.'
- b. Na-waca-ngang **nasang** i [EXT kindo'-na *pro*] [GOAL sanaeke ____].
 3ERG-read-APPL every 3ABS mom-3GEN her kid
 'Her_{ij} mom read to every_i kid.'

3.1.3 Reconstruction and A-Movement

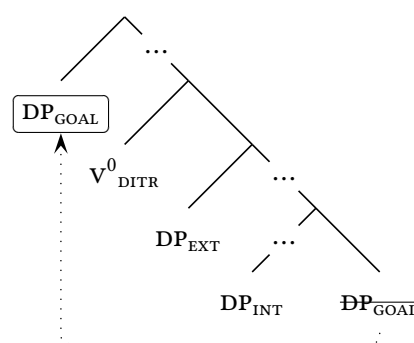
These asymmetries in binding reveal that there is a second type of structural privilege that systematically falls to the absolutive DP: beyond interacting with τ^0 , this argument must invariably raise—in a manner not typically reflected in the word order—to a position that c-commands all the other arguments in the clause. In the presence of transitive verbs, this step targets the INT (26a); in the presence of ditransitive verbs, it targets the GOAL (26b).

(26) *Absolutive Arguments: Raise to a High Position in Mandar*

a. *Transitive: High INT*



b. *Ditransitive: High GOAL*



The particular impact of this movement on the systems of binding and coreference, in turn, fits naturally with the understanding that it is bound up with the assignment of abstract Case. Since the work of Postal 1971 and Chomsky 1981, it has become traditional to divide phrasal movements into two classes: A-movements and $\bar{A}$ -movements. The body of work that follows in this tradition has found that the movements in these two classes interact in consistent ways with many independent systems in the syntax, and as a result, there are rich and far-reaching correlations between the ways that individual steps of movement interact with patterns of binding, case-assignment, and ϕ -agreement (along with other systems; for an overview, see Safir 2019). For our purposes, the most important correlation is the following: the steps of movement bound up with the assignment of Case—and thus subjecthood—should be A-movements, which have the ability to alter patterns of pronominal coreference and variable binding. If the absolutive DP is raised by systems that position it to receive Case from τ^0 , then, we should expect the ensuing steps of movement to deliver the exact type of binding privilege that we have seen above.

We can tighten this identification with a short foray into the system of reconstruction. In a manner that cannot be reduced to the facts of linear order, Richards 2000 and Pearson 2005 show that variable binding works in a very similar way in Tagalog and Malagasy: in

the terminology of the present investigation, nominal arguments gain the ability to bind into the ergative DP in those languages whenever they receive abstract absolutive Case. In spite of this fact, these authors propose that these DPs are carried up to their high position by a step of $\bar{A}$ -movement: one unrelated to the TP-level systems of Case-assignment and disconnected from the syntax of subjecthood (*pace* the analyses of those languages put forward by Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992). Setting aside a generalization about reflexive anaphors that turns out to be irrelevant to this debate (for reasons both internal to Malagasy: Paul 2004 and more general: Brodtkin & Royer 2024), the primary argument for this view is a fact of reconstruction: when ergative DPs are quantified, they can still bind variables in the absolutive DP. This fact is true in Mandar as well, and it is shown in example (27).

(27) *Variable Binding: Absolutive Arguments Reconstruct*

$\downarrow$
 Na-waca nasang i [EXT panulis ____] [INT buku-na pro].
 3ERG-read every 3ABS author book-3GEN
 ‘Every_i author read her_{i,j} book.’

The immediate force of this fact is to show that the absolutive DP is raised to its high position by a process that can reconstruct for variable binding. But there is no case to be made from this fact for the $\bar{A}$ -analysis, because reconstruction for variable binding is a well-known property of A-movement. In English, for instance, Lebeaux 1991 shows that raising to subject allows this type of reconstruction: when arguments that contain variables raise across quantified PPs, they can freely reconstruct to positions beneath them.

$\downarrow$
 (28) His_i mother seems to every boy_i [____ to be a genius]. Lebeaux 1991, 231

The actual import of this observation, then, is to establish another argument for the A-analysis: like A-movement, the processes that position the absolutive DP allow reconstruction for variable binding but do not force it. Building from the facts of reconstruction, moreover, we can now build a second connection in the domain of Condition C. In English, A-movement shows a split: while it can reconstruct for variable binding, it cannot reconstruct for Condition C. When nominative DPs A-move across experiencer PPs, then, they cannot be pronouns coindexed with R-expressions within them.

$\downarrow$
 (29) *He_i seems to John’s_i mother [____ to be a genius].

If the absolutive DP is raised by a parallel type of A-movement in Mandar, then, it should not reconstruct for Condition C: in other words, it should be unable to be coindexed

with R-expressions in the DPs beneath it. This prediction is correct: the transitive INT (30a) and ditransitive GOAL (30b) cannot be pronouns coindexed with R-expressions in the EXT.

(30) *Condition C: Absolutive Arguments Cannot Reconstruct*

- a. Na-peroa i [EXT sola-na iAli na iMina] [INT *pro*] dionging.
 3ERG-invite 3ABS friend-3GEN NAME and NAME him yesterday
 ‘Ali_i and Mina’s friends invited him_{*i,j} yesterday.’
- b. Na-waca-ngang i [EXT kindo’na iAli na iMina] [GOAL *pro*] digena’.
 3ERG-read-APPL 3ABS mom-3GEN NAME and NAME him earlier
 ‘Ali_i and Mina’s mom read to him_{*i,j} earlier.’

We thus emerge from our study of binding and reconstruction with two lines of evidence that the absolutive DP undergoes a systematic and covert step of A-movement above all other arguments in the clause. The task that follows is to understand how.

3.2 The Low Subject Position

The literature on High Absolutive Syntax suggests two ways to interpret the evidence for A-movement above. The first, put forward by Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992, draws on the initial discovery of two distinct subject positions to place the absolutive DP in the middlefield: for instance, in SPEC,TP. The second, building on the later discovery of further A-positions for objects along the clausal spine (Johnson, 1991; Takano, 1998), places the absolutive DP much lower in the clause: for instance, in the highest A-position at the edge of the clause-internal phase (Aldridge 2004; see also Rackowski 2002 for an approach that yields a similar result through appeal to definiteness-related object shift (Diesing, 1992)). The natural path of our investigation, then, will lead us directly into this debate.

3.2.1 Raising in Non-Finite Clauses

Mandar has a subordinating preposition *mau* ‘though’ that can select complement clauses of several different sizes, and one of these is shown in example (31a): a non-finite clause that hosts all the usual heads of the middle field except the marker of absolutive agreement. Brodtkin 2025c argues that these clauses show the syntax in (31b): they project only up to the highest visible layer of functional structure they contain (in this case, PolP).

(31) *Mau “Though”: Non-Finite Complement Clauses*

- a. **Mau** ndang ____ rua na-ita dio di perpus, masskripsi i de’.
 though not ever 3ERG-see there in library dissertate 3ABS allegedly
 ‘Though never seen in the library, he’s allegedly working on his thesis’
- b. $[_{PP} mau_{P^0} [_{POLP} NEG^0 [_{ASPP} AUX^0 [_{voiceP} \dots]]]]$

Unlike all other environments that lack absolutive agreement in Mandar, these complement clauses can host overt absolutive DPS (32a). Brodtkin 2025c thus proposes that they show a distinct syntax of Case-licensing: they allow the absolutive DP to receive abstract Case from the subordinating P^0 , on a par with the *for-to* clauses of English (32b).

(32) *Mau-Complements: Exceptional Case-Marking*

- a. Mau $[_{POLP}$ ndang rua na-pikkiri $[_{EXT}$ iAli $]$ $[_{INT}$ penutupang $]$,
 though not ever 3ERG-think of NAME conclusion
 ‘Though Ali hasn’t thought about [–FIN] the conclusion,’
- b. $[_{PP} mau_{P^0} [_{POLP} NEG^0 AUX^0 [_{voiceP} V DP_{ERG} DP_{ABS}]]]$

These *though*-clauses are important to the present investigation for the following fact: even in the absence of the functional structure of the middle field, they require the absolutive DP to show all of its usual privileges in the systems of pronominal coreference and variable binding. Thus when *mau* selects a bare transitive *voiceP*, the INT still seems to c-command the EXT for the purposes of Condition C: it can contain an R-expression coindexed with a pronominal EXT (33a) and cannot be a pronoun coindexed with an R-expression in that DP (33b).

(33) *Condition C: Absolutive INT > Ergative EXT in the VoiceP*

- a. Mau $[_{voiceP}$ na-waca $[_{EXT}$ *pro* $]$ $[_{INT}$ buku-na iAli $]$ $]$ dionging,
 though 3ERG-read he book-3GEN NAME yesterday
 ‘Though he_{i,j} read [–FIN] Ali_i’s book yesterday,’
- b. Mau $[_{voiceP}$ na-peroa $[_{EXT}$ sola-na iAli na iMina $]$ $[_{INT}$ *pro* $]$,
 though 3ERG-invite friend-3GEN NAME and NAME him
 ‘Though Ali_i and Mina’s friends invited [–FIN] him_{*i,j},’

In the system of variable binding, the facts are the same: when *mau* selects a transitive *voiceP*, a quantified INT can still bind into the EXT—a pattern that holds even though the quantifier *nasang* must remain adnominal in this context (34a). The step of movement

that licenses this pattern, moreover, allows the same type of reconstruction that we have seen in finite clauses: in these clauses, too, the INT can be bound by a quantified EXT (34b).

(34) *Variable Binding: Absolutive INT > Ergative EXT in the VoiceP*

- a. Mau [voiceP na-waca [EXT panulis-na pro] [INT buku nasang]],
 though 3ERG-read author-3GEN its book every
 ‘Though its author_{ij} read [−FIN] every_i book,’
- b. Mau [voiceP na-waca [EXT panulis nasang] [INT buku-na pro]],
 though 3ERG-read author every book-3GEN her
 ‘Though every_i author read [−FIN] her_{ij} book,’

The result is a straightforward case that the absolutive DP must raise even in the absence of the usual functional structure of the TP. On the view that the complement clauses in (33)-(34) project only up to the level of the *voiceP*, moreover (a result essentially forced by the low position of *nasang*: Brodkin 2025c), it stands to reason that the absolutive DP must already raise above all other arguments in the clause within the *voiceP*—likely drawn up to its edge along the lines proposed for Tagalog by Aldridge 2004 and many other High Absolutive languages in later work (Coon *et al.*, 2014; Royer, 2023; Erlewine & Lim, 2023).

3.2.2 Absolutive Preposing

It is against this backdrop that we can introduce one final fact of linear order. Under a fine network of phonological conditions laid out by Brodkin 2025a, there is a context where absolutive DPs are forced to surface in a linear position that falls between the *voiceP* and the auxiliaries of the extended TP. The essential effect is shown in the examples below: in a clause that contains a string of auxiliaries, a transitive verb, and an absolutive INT, the INT must surface in its usual postverbal position (35a). But when an additional prosodic word is introduced into the *voiceP*—for instance, if an EXT is introduced into that string—the INT is forced to surface between the verb and the auxiliaries above (35b).

(35) *Linear Evidence: Absolutive DPs → Edge of the VoiceP*

- a. Rua i yari [voiceP na-saka [INT iAli]].
 once 3ABS DID 3ERG-catch NAME
 ‘They once DID arrest Ali.’
- b. Rua i yari [voiceP [INT iAli] na-saka [EXT polisi] ____].
 once 3ABS DID NAME 3ERG-catch police
 ‘The police once DID arrest Ali.’

Brodkin 2025a shows that this alternation is governed by constraints on balance that guide the system of chain reduction at the syntax-prosody interface, and the details of that account are irrelevant to our present work. What is important is a restriction in the syntax: the only DPs that can surface at the edge of the *voiceP* are those that should receive absolutive Case. In the presence of transitive verbs, then, this step must target the INT and cannot target the EXT. In the presence of ditransitive verbs, in turn, it must target the GOAL (36a). And in the presence of antipassive verbs, it must target the EXT (36b).

(36) *Linear Evidence: Absolutive DPs → Edge of the VoiceP*

- a. Ndang i rua [voiceP [GOAL iCicci'] na-carita-ngang [INT rasia]] ____ .
 not 3ABS ever NAME 3ERG-tell-APPL secret
 ‘He never told Chichi’ the secret.’
- b. Ndang i rua [voiceP [EXT iCicci'] ma'-ande ____ [INT boe]] .
 not 3ABS ever NAME ANTIP-eat pork
 ‘Chichi’ never ate pork.’

Taking this high position to be SPEC,*voiceP*, we thus arrive at a two-part case for the syntax in (37): no matter the voice of the verb or the identity of the absolutive DP, it systematically raises to SPEC,*voiceP*. In verb-initial clauses, this step is typically covert—yielding *voiceP*-level binding privilege for the absolutive DP and the linear order VSOD. But under the conditions that force this effect, the absolutive DP is realized in SPEC,*voiceP*.

(37) *The Low Subject Position*

- a. ANTIPASSIVE: [voiceP S V [vP S [applP [vP O] D]]]].
- b. TRANSITIVE: [voiceP Θ V [vP S [vP O]]]].
- c. DITRANSITIVE: [voiceP Θ V [vP S [applP [vP O] D]]]].

This conclusion establishes the first link in our wider case for subjechood: the absolutive DP consistently moves to a dedicated landing site, defined by the formal requirement to fill SPEC,*voiceP*, that systematically attracts the transitive INT, ditransitive GOAL, and antipassive EXT. This analytical step separates our analysis of the High Absolutive configuration from a broad range of alternatives, following Aldridge 2004, that deny a consistent position to the absolutive DP and simply require absolutive Case to fall to the highest DP at the edge of the clause-internal phase. Its force, in turn, is to establish a singular launching point for a higher series of interactions that will ultimately allow the absolutive DP to receive Case from τ^0 —a launching point I will term the LOW SUBJECT POSITION below.

3.3 Locality and Activity

We can now prepare to advance to the middle field with a brief turn to the syntax of Case. In transitive and ditransitive clauses, we have seen, the low subject position forces a step of attraction that skips over the ergative DP to draw up the INT and the GOAL (38a). In this respect, it breaks from the heads that define subject positions in nominative-accusative systems (38b), which typically attract the highest DP in the *voiceP* (but cf. Miyagawa 2001; Bailyn 2004). We are thus forced to ask: why should this divergence emerge?

(38) *The Puzzle of Locality*

- a. HIGH-ABSOLUTIVE ATTRACTION: $\left[\text{voiceP } \text{voice}_{\text{TRANS}} \left[\text{vP } \text{DP}_{\text{ERG}} \left[\text{VP } \text{V } \text{DP}_{\text{ABS}} \right] \right] \right]$
- b. REGULAR A-MOVEMENT: $\left[\text{voiceP } \text{voice}_{\text{TRANS}} \left[\text{vP } \text{DP}_{\text{NOM}} \left[\text{VP } \text{V } \text{DP}_{\text{ACC}} \right] \right] \right]$

3.3.1 Getting around the Ergative DP

The natural solution to this puzzle lies in the domain of Case. In transitive and ditransitive *voiceP*s, we have seen that ergative DPs trigger agreement on *voice*⁰—and in tandem with this fact, these DPs surface freely in non-finite environments. These facts suggest that the formal needs of the ergative DP can be satisfied by the functional structure of the extended VP—and more specifically, that the ϕ -probe on *voice*⁰ licenses that DP with abstract Case.

(39) *Ergative Case-Assignment*

- $\left[\text{voiceP } \text{voice}_{\text{TRANS}} \left[\text{vP } \text{DP}_{\text{ERG}} \left[\text{VP } \text{V } \text{DP}_{\text{ABS}} \right] \right] \right]$

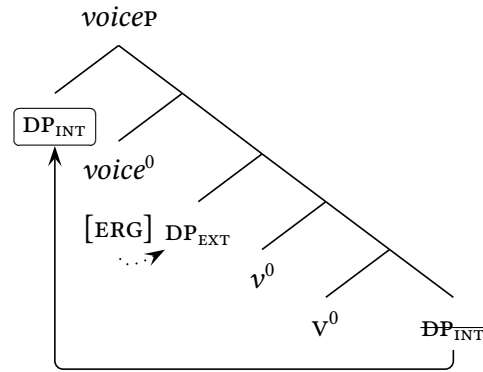
The first result of this analytical step is a link to the wider theory of ergative Case. On the basis of similar facts, it has been argued that ergative Case originates in the *voiceP* in many families beyond Austronesian (e.g., Inuit (Bok-Bennema, 1991; Bittner & Hale, 1996a,b), Salishan (Wiltschko, 2006), and Mayan (Coon *et al.*, 2014)). Across these systems, then, ergative DPs show the same type of syntax as other non-subject DPs: their formal needs are met by a network of relationships they establish with the functional heads of the extended VP. It is this property that allows them to surface in non-finite clauses, on a par with objects that receive accusative Case (Johnson, 1991; Kratzer, 1996), and it is this property that allows them to avoid interaction with the functional heads of the TP.

The second consequence of this step is a path to derive the invisibility of the ergative DP. To capture the pattern of High Absolutive attraction, the literature has long appealed to the logic of Activity (Chomsky, 2001): when A-probes reach into the extended VP, they

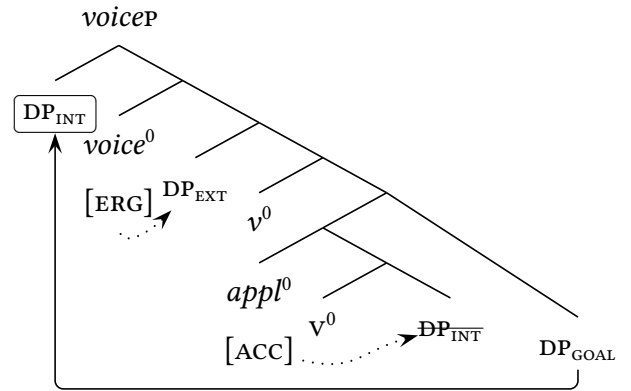
skip past the ergative DPs that have already received Case (Guilfoyle *et al.*, 1992; Bittner & Hale, 1996a,b; Legate, 2014). The result is a framework that links the special pattern of locality to a reversal in the *voiceP*-level system of Case: the transitive EXT will always receive Case but the transitive INT and ditransitive GOAL will not, and as a result, it is only those arguments that will be visible to the A-probe that defines the low subject position.

(40) *High Absolutive Syntax: Absolutive DPs Lack Case in the VoiceP*

a. *Transitive: Caseless INT*



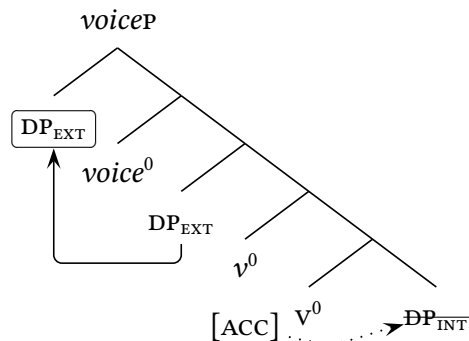
b. *Ditransitive: Caseless GOAL*



3.3.2 Understanding the Antipassive

From this perspective, we can assign a clear and precise syntax to the system of Austronesian voice: it guides the patterns of Case-assignment and movement to ensure that (i) every nominal argument except one will receive structural Case within the *voiceP*, and (ii) this last DP—the absolutive—will raise to the low subject position at the *voiceP* edge. Extending this analysis to the antipassive, we conclude with the following result: the antipassive *voice*⁰ must fail assign to ergative Case to the EXT, forcing it to raise, and the antipassive *v*⁰ must assign accusative Case to the INT, allowing it to stay low. Put differently, that voice must show something like a nominative-accusative pattern of licensing.

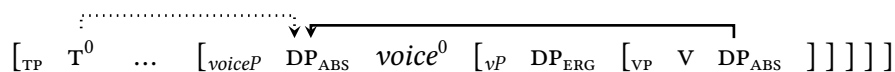
(41) *Antipassive: Caseless EXT*



4 The High Subject Position

The theory of clause structure that emerges from these parts is one that neatly positions the absolutive DP to interact with the functional structure of the extended TP. This possibility emerges in part from the systems of relative locality and Case, which converge to make the absolutive DP the closest and neediest target for ϕ -probes in the middle field (42). But it is also reinforced by an intuition from the domain of absolute locality: namely, the hypothesis that all material beneath SPEC,voiceP will be rendered invisible to the TP by the boundary of a phase. This pair of expectations has driven the range of proposals, after Aldridge 2004, that place absolutive DPs at the edge of the clause-internal phase in other systems where they receive Case from τ^0 (Erlewine, 2018; Erlewine & Lim, 2023; Coon *et al.*, 2014; Royer, 2023). And this positional expectation has now been redeemed, in a relatively straightforward way, by all the facts of the language that we have already seen.

(42) *Low Subject Position: Launches the Absolutive DP into the Middle Field*



Against this backdrop, we can now raise a second question of position: how much higher does the absolutive DP raise? Taking the facts of word order seriously, for instance, we might assume—after Aldridge 2004—that the absolutive DP does not raise past the edge of the voiceP. This is because the pressures that force subjects to raise to higher positions in the middle field are now widely understood to emerge from the idiosyncratic and cross-linguistically variable properties of individual heads. It is this type of idiosyncrasy that gives rise to the staggering diversity of behavior among subjects (Cardinaletti, 2004), and from this same idiosyncrasy emerges the possibility that some systems will feature no obligatory middle-field positions at all (McCloskey, 1997; Cable, 2012). We may thus be dealing with the “stop and tap” syntax in (42): one on which the absolutive DP moves to the low subject position, receives Case in-situ from τ^0 , and never raises out of the voiceP.

4.1 The Test Case

But there is good evidence to suggest that such an analysis of Mandar would not be correct, and it turns on the behavior of a wide set of nominals that move in a curiously overt way. Setting aside *nasang* ‘every’ and a range of related quantifiers that subextract in finite clauses (Brodkin, 2025c), the functional heads of the Mandar DP typically appear before

the noun (Brodkin, To Appear). In this space appear two categories of interest: the strong quantifiers *inggannanna* ‘all’ and *ianasanna* ‘each’ (43a) and a range of weak quantifiers that include *mai’di* ‘many,’ *sicco* ‘a few,’ and all numerals (43b). I assume that these elements spell out quantificational heads and I will refer to these constituents as qps below.

(43) *Quantificational Phrases in Mandar*

- a. [_{QP} Inggannanna_Q bonde], [_{QP} ianasanna_Q batu bonde]
 all sand each grain sand
 ‘All the sand, each grain of sand’
- b. [_{QP} Mai’di_Q anjoro], [_{QP} sicco_Q ’ anjoro], [_{QP} tallu_Q anjoro]
 many coconut few coconut three coconut
 ‘Many coconuts, a few coconuts, three coconuts.’

These qps are useful because they wear their syntactic positions on their sleeves. In the contexts where they take the positions of absolutive DPs, then, it is generally ungrammatical for them to surface in the usual postverbal positions of argument DPs. What happens instead is shown in (44): when a strong QP takes the position of a transitive INT in a non-finite clause, it must be realized in the low subject position—even outside of the prosodic configuration that forces that pattern of spell-out for ordinary absolutive DPs.

(44) *Quantified Absolutive Arguments: Always Move Overtly*

- Mau rua yari [_{voiceP} [_{INT} inggannanna paccoro] na-saka ____].
 though once DID all thief 3ERG-catch
 ‘Though once they DID catch [–FIN] all the thieves,’

This step of movement shows all the syntactic properties of the process that raises the absolutive DP. First, it targets the same linear position—the juncture between the lowest overt auxiliary and the verb. Second, it fills this position with a single QP—and as a result, it never attracts multiple QPs to the same landing site. The following examples illustrate: when the INT and the GOAL are both quantified in a ditransitive *voiceP*, this process applies to the GOAL and leaves the INT in its usual postverbal position (45a). It is ungrammatical, in this context, for the INT to be drawn up to the same juncture in the same way (45b).

(45) *Quantificational Phrases: Movement only targets the Absolutive*

- a. Mau rua [_{voiceP} [_{GOAL} ing. sola-u] u-carita-ngang [_{INT} ing. fakta] _],
 though once all friend-1GEN 1ERG-tell-APPL all fact
 ‘Though once I told [–FIN] all my friends all the facts,’

- b. *Mau rua [voiceP [GOAL ing. tau] [INT ing. fakta] u-carita-ngang ____],
 though once all person all fact 1ERG-tell-APPL
 ‘Though once I told [–FIN] everyone all the facts,’

Third, this process can only target absolutive QPs. It thus fails to apply to QPs in all other positions—for instance, those in PPs and those adjoined to the *voiceP* (46).

(46) *Quantificational Phrases: Only Move When Absolutive*

- Mau byasa [voiceP ____ sita [PP sola ing. tau]] [AJT tuttu allo],
 though usually meet with all person every day
 ‘Though usually meeting [–FIN] with everyone every day,’

Fourth and finally, this process has a familiar impact on the systems of pronominal coreference and variable binding. To begin, it fails to reconstruct for Condition C—and thus when absolutive QPs raise in this way, they can always contain R-expressions that are coindexed with the EXT (47a). In the same vein, it introduces new possibilities for variable binding—and thus it is always possible for these QPs to bind variables in the EXT (47b).

(47) *Quantificational Phrases: Evidence for A-Movement*

- a. Mau rua [voiceP [INT ing. sola-na iAli] na-ita [EXT pro] ____].
 though once all friend-3GEN NAME 3ERG-see
 ‘Once he_{ij} saw [–FIN] all of Ali’s $_i$ friends.’
- b. Mau byasa [voiceP [INT ian. kindo’] na-ita [EXT sanaeke-na pro] ____].
 though usually each mom 3ERG-see child-3GEN her
 ‘Though usually her_{ij} kid sees [–FIN] each mom $_i$.’

These facts suggest that absolutive QPs are drawn into the low subject position by the very same syntax that attracts regular absolutive DPs. What separates these two steps of movement, on this view, is a purely surface-level fact: the language requires QPs to be spelled out in the highest positions they pass through. This understanding will be essential to our case for a higher syntax of subjecthood, and it is sketched in diagram (48).

(48) *An Asymmetry in Spell-Out*

- a. A-MOEMENT OF DPs = COVERT
- ↓
- [voiceP DP_{ABS} voice⁰ [vP DP_{ERG} [vP v DP_{ABS}]]]
- b. A-MOEMENT OF QPs = OVERT
- ↓
- [voiceP QP_{ABS} voice⁰ [vP DP_{ERG} [vP v QP_{ABS}]]]

4.2 The Head ASP^0

When we introduce slightly more structure into the Mandar middle field, the absolutive QPs that raise to the low subject position must surface farther to the left. The key effect turns on a pair of second-position enclitics that surface in complementary distribution and mark distinctions of outer aspect: *mo* ‘already’ and *pa* ‘yet.’ These elements belong to a class that is well-studied across the South Sulawesi subfamily (Strømme, 1994; Friberg, 1996; Matti, 1994; Valkama, 1995a; Jukes, 2006; Laskowske, 2016), and we can pin down their rough syntax with four facts. First, they can surface in the non-finite *though*-clauses that lack absolutive agreement (49a). In that context, second, they are forced to follow the highest overt auxiliary or verb—exactly like the absolutive enclitics. From that position, third, they are forced to take scope over their hosts—like the negator in example (49b).

(49) *The Aspectual Enclitics*

- a. Mau yari **mo** [_{voiceP} u-ita [_{INT} iAli]],
 though DID ALREADY 1ERG-see NAME
 ‘Though I already DID see [−FIN] Ali,’
- b. Mau ndang **mo** [_{voiceP} u-ita [_{INT} iAli]],
 though not ALREADY 1ERG-see NAME
 ‘Though I no longer see [−FIN] Ali,’ (ALREADY > NOT)

Fourth and finally, in finite clauses, these enclitics cluster together with the absolutive agreement enclitics and combine with them in phonologically irregular ways. The sequence /*mo-i*/ ALREADY-3ABS, for instance, is realized as [*mi*], while the sequence /*mo-a*/ ALREADY-1ABS is realized [*ma*’] (50). Brodtkin 2022 shows that these forms must be treated as portmanteaux, much like their counterparts across the subfamily (e.g., Valkama 1995a).

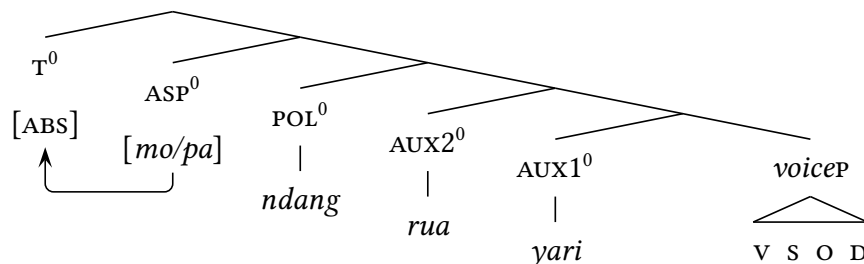
(50) *The Aspectual Enclitics: Portmanteaux with Absolutive Agreement*

- Massau **mi**, yari malai **ma**’.
 recover ALREADY.3ABS so return ALREADY.1ABS
 ‘He’s already recovered, so I’ve already returned.’ Friberg & Jerniati 2000, 174

What these facts collectively suggest is the syntax in (51): *mo* and *pa* spell out a head in the middle field, ASP^0 , that sits above POL^0 and below T^0 . The high position of this head provides a natural explanation for the facts of scope (ASP^0 scopes above NEG because it sits above it), and it delivers a similar path to understand the facts of linear order (like absolutive agreement, *mo/pa* are postsyntactically placed after the highest head beneath

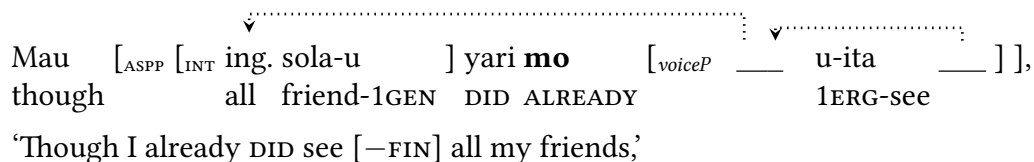
them). On the view that syntactic locality constraints govern the formation of portman-teaux, moreover, it also allows us to understand the patterns in (51) on the view that ASP^0 moves into T^0 , placing *mo* and *pa* into a complex head with absolutive agreement.

(51) *The Mandar Middle Field: Revised*



Turning back to the non-finite complements of *mau*, we can now see the key syntactic effect of the head ASP^0 . When we introduce *mo/pa* into these clauses, it becomes ungrammatical for absolutive QPs to remain in the low subject position. Instead, they are forced to raise to a higher landing site—one that falls above the highest auxiliary (52).

(52) *The Asp Head → Higher Movement for Absolutive QPs*

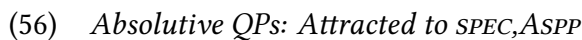


This process shows all the characteristic properties of movement driven by the formal needs of an attracting head. First, it can only target a single QP—on a par with the process that raises the absolutive QP to the low subject position in non-finite clauses. Second, it can only the highest QP—and thus when the INT and GOAL are both quantified the ditransitive, it must target the GOAL and leave the INT in the *voiceP* (53).

(53) *The Asp Head → Only Attracts the Absolutive QP*

- a. Mau [ASPP [G ing. tau] yari mo [voiceP — u-carita-ngang [I ing. fakta] _]],
 though all guy DID ASP 1ERG-tell-APPL all fact
 ‘Though I already DID tell [–FIN] everyone all the facts,’
- b. *Mau [ASPP [G ing. tau] [I ing. fakta] yari mo [voiceP — u-carita-ngang _ _]],
 though all guy all fact DID ASP 1ERG-tell-APPL
 INTENDED: ‘Though I already DID tell [–FIN] everyone all the facts,’

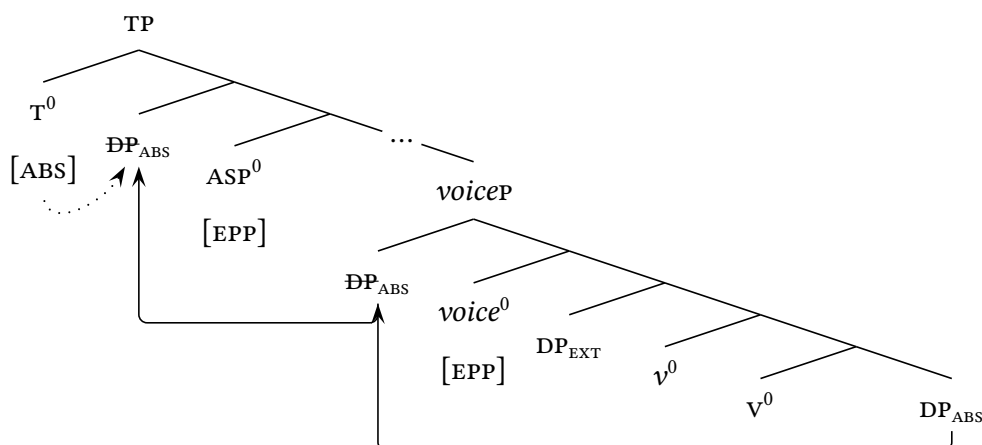
(54) *The Asp Head $\rightarrow$ Only Attracts QPs from the Low Subject Position*



4.3 The Syntax of Subjecthood

We are now in a position to redeem the foundational hypothesis of syntactic parallelism between QPs and DPs—and more specifically, the empirical observation that absolutive DPs seem to move covertly through the exact set of positions that visibly attract absolutive QPs. Within the *voiceP*, we have seen that this parallel holds in the low subject position, whose formal needs force movement of both absolutive DPs and QPs. At the level of the TP, then, it seems natural to extend the same logic to the head ASP^0 —and take the formal requirements that force movement of absolutive QPs to drive covert movement of absolutive DPs as well. This view leads us to posit the syntax in (58): one on which there is a second and higher subject position, falling just beneath the TP, that requires its specifier to be filled and thus attracts absolutive DPs from the low subject position to position them to interact with T^0 .

(58) *The High Subject Position*



On this view, the usual facts of linear order mask a rich and canonical syntax of subjecthood: one on which the absolutive DP enters into a cascading series of relationships with higher heads that carry it through a sequence of subject positions and ultimately culminate in the assignment of Case. In this respect, the Mandarin absolutive DP shows the exact type of syntax that might be expected of a preverbal nominative DP and diverges from those types of arguments only at the postsyntactic stage that determines the positions where A-moved DPs are pronounced. This conclusion echoes the results of a long tradition of work that has found delicate evidence for the raising of postverbal DPs that receive nominative Case (see e.g., McCloskey 2017), but it runs against the intuitions of much work on verb-initial ergative systems that show little overt movement of the absolutive DP. Its wider force, then, is to raise the possibility that postverbal absolutive DPs may much more often show a fine syntax of subjecthood that is fully covert.

5 Two Layers of Expletives

The analysis that has now come together is one that emerges from four language-internal claims: (i) the Austronesian voice system emerges from the layered interaction of a regular middle field syntax of subjecthood with a VP-level syntax of *voice* that defines a lower subject position and guides the assignment of Case; (ii) this system forces the absolutive DP to raise through two defined subject positions in response to the formal needs of heads along the clausal spine; (iii) the relevant steps of A-movement are canonically covert; and (iv) their paths are only revealed by the idiosyncratic and language-specific fact that movement of QPs is always overt. While assumption (iii) is common in the wider context of Austronesian, however, claims (i) and (ii) are contested and property (iv) is unknown. It is thus an important fact that each of these three final components is required to explain the final corner of this system: the middle field syntax of weak QPs. The fine effects that emerge in this domain will reveal a total breakdown of the relationship between the high and low systems of subjecthood, and our ensuing investigation will reveal two distinct layers of expletive insertion and strengthen the case that the high subject position exists.

5.1 Weakly Quantified Nominals

The class of weakly quantified nominals show a network of properties that seem relatively expected in the framework that we have built so far. When these elements take the position of the absolutive DP, most importantly, they raise in an ordinary and consistently overt fashion to the low subject position in non-finite clauses that lack the head ASP⁰ (59).

(59) *Weakly Quantified Nominals* → *Low Subject Position*

$\downarrow$
 Mau yari [_{voiceP} [_{QP} lima boyang] u-landur ____],
 though DID five house 1ERG-go past
 ‘Though I DID walk past [–FIN] five houses,’

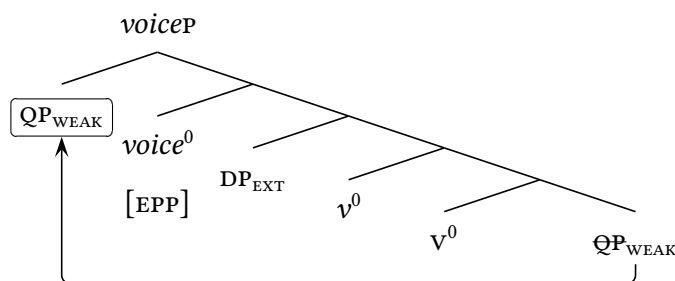
This step of movement, in turn, shows all the usual hallmarks of attraction to the low subject position. First, it strictly targets a single QP: when both the GOAL and the INT are weakly quantified, it draws up the GOAL with no regard to the relative scope of the two QPs (60a). Second, it reshapes patterns of pronominal coreference: the weak QPs that raise in this way will never reconstruct for Condition C and can thus contain R-expressions coindexed with the EXT (60b). Third and finally, it never applies to weak QPs outside of nominal argument positions, such as those embedded in PPs or adjoined to the VP (60c).

(60) *Weakly Quantified Nominals: Evidence for Attraction*

- a. Mau rua [GOAL tallu lessang] u-be-ngang [INT sappulo loka] ,
 though once three monkey 1ERG-give-APPL ten banana
 ‘Though I once gave [–FIN] three monkeys ten bananas,’ (✓3>10; ✓10>3)
- b. Mau rua [o tallu buku-na iAli] na-padai’ [s pro] di lingbuzz,
 though once three book-3GEN NAME 3ERG-upload he on SITE
 ‘Though he_{i,j} once uploaded [–FIN] three of Ali_i’s books onto lingbuzz,’
- c. Rua i [voice sicaka iAli [PP sola 3 setang] [AJT san-jang]].
 once 3ABS convene NAME with 3 demons one-hour
 ‘Ali once convened with three demons for an hour.’

Weak absolutive QPs thus seem to move to the low subject position in the usual way. In the language-particular fashion of QPs, moreover, they seem to be systematically spelled out in the highest positions to which they move, yielding the *voiceP*-level syntax in (61).

(61) *Weak QPs → Low Subject Position*



When we turn to the higher syntax of the middle field, however, the usual syntax breaks down. In the non-finite clauses that host *mo/pa*, weak absolutive QPs fail to raise to the high subject position. In this context, rather, they remain in the low subject position.

(62) *Weakly Quantified Nominals → Never Raise Past the Low Subject Position*

- Mau [ASPP ____ yari **mo**] [voiceP [QP lima boyang] u-landur ____] ,
 though DID ALREADY five house 1ERG-go past
 ‘Though I already DID walk past [–FIN] five houses,’

We thus arrive at a fact that threatens the entire analytical framework we have built up to this point: in the context at hand, the surface failure of raising may suggest that the high subject position is simply not filled (63a)—undercutting the case that it always draws up absolutive DPs. As an alternative, the failure of raising may suggest that weak QPs can

be drawn up to this position in a manner that is exceptionally covert (63b)—undermining the empirical generalization about QPs that has been central to our wider case. Finally, as a last possibility, this lack of movement may suggest that the high subject position is filled with a type of null expletive (63c)—the sole option consistent with our framework and thus one that would require clear and careful empirical justification.

(63) *High Subject Position: Three Possibilities*

a. EMPTY SPEC,ASPP:

[_{ASPP} ____ ... [_{voiceP} $\overset{\downarrow}{\text{QP}_{\text{WEAK}}}$... [_{VP} QP_{WEAK}]]]

b. COVERT MOVEMENT:

[_{ASPP} $\overset{\downarrow}{\text{QP}_{\text{WEAK}}}$... [_{voiceP} QP_{WEAK} ... [_{VP} QP_{WEAK}]]]

c. NULL EXPLETIVE:

[_{ASPP} EXPL ... [_{voiceP} $\overset{\downarrow}{\text{QP}_{\text{WEAK}}}$... [_{VP} QP_{WEAK}]]]

We can round out the shape of the problem with three further observations. In the contexts where weak absolute QPs raise to the low subject position, first, it is not possible for the high subject position to reach into the *voiceP* and fill itself with anything else. When a weakly quantified GOAL raises to the low subject position, then, the high subject position cannot reach past it to draw up a strongly quantified but non-absolute INT.

(64) *High Subject Position: Cannot Skip Past the Low Subject Position*

- a. Mau ____ yari **mo** [_{voiceP} [_D 3 lessang] u-be-ngang [_o ing. loka]]],
 though DID ASP 3 monkey 1ERG-give-APPL all banana
 ‘Though I already DID give [–FIN] three monkeys all the bananas,’

Second, the apparent emptiness of the high subject position correlates with a total disruption to the system of absolute agreement. When weak QPs raise to the low subject position in root clauses, they fail to control agreement in T^0 .

(65) *Weak Absolute QPs → Absolute Agreement Disappears*

- [_{TP} Biasa (*i) [_{voiceP} [_{WQ} lima boyang] na-landur _]] mua' lo i ma'jama.
 usually 3ABS five house 3ERG-go past as he goes to work
 ‘He usually walks past five houses as he goes to work.’

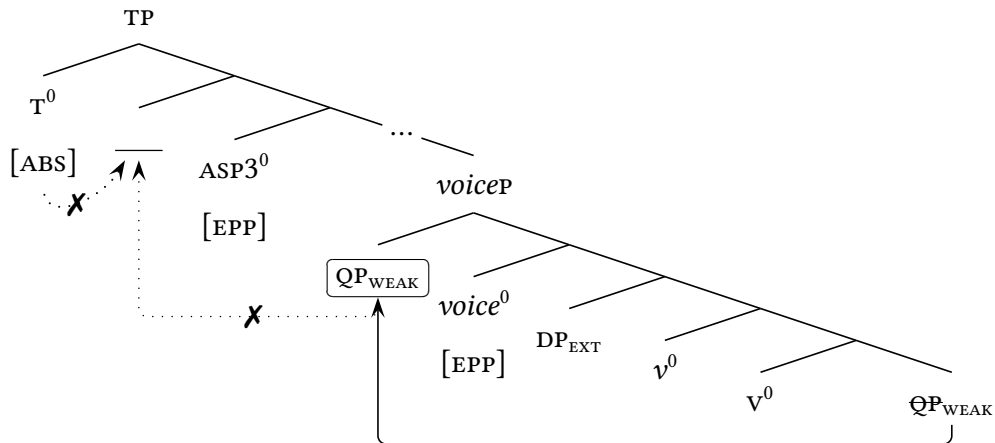
Third and finally, it is equally impossible for the system of absolutive agreement to reach into the *voiceP* and interact with anything else. Just as the high subject position cannot skip over weak QPs in the low subject position, the ϕ -probe on T^0 cannot skip these elements to target the ditransitive INT or EXT (66). The result is the sole exception to an otherwise ironclad trend: in these root clauses, absolutive agreement does not appear.

(66) *Agreement on T^0 : Cannot Skip Past the Low Subject Position*

Ndang **pa_/*o/*a'** [voiceP [_D mesa terapís] u-kiring-ang [_S *pro*] [_O *pro*].
 not YET_/2ABS/1ABS one therapist 1ERG-send-APPL 1SG 2SG
 ‘I haven’t sent you to a single therapist yet.’

The force of these facts is to suggest a collapse of the feeding relationship between the lower and higher systems of subjecthood: weak QPs can meet the needs of *voice*⁰ and raise into the low subject position, but—taking seriously the language-internal generalization that movement of QPs is always overt—it would seem that they fail to meet the needs of the high subject position, fail to raise into the middle field, and fail to interact with T^0 (67). As a result, it is not at all clear how the formal needs of *ASP*⁰ and T^0 are met—and on the view that the feature [EPP] must always be satisfied for derivations to converge, it is thus unclear whether *ASP*⁰ bears this feature or whether the high subject position exists at all.

(67) *The Breakdown in Subjecthood*



5.2 The Case for Expletives

It is thus an impressive and telling fact that there is evidence—indirect but clear—that in this context the high subject position is filled by a null expletive of a particular type. The

remain low—and there is no overt evidence that the low and high subject positions of the matrix clause are filled. But despite this fact, they force the disappearance of absolutive agreement in the matrix clause—as if their presence in the low subject position of the embedded clause set up a chain reaction that derailed the matrix syntax of subjecthood.

(71) *Raising Constructions: Weak QPs Fail to Raise*

$\begin{array}{c} \vdots \\ \downarrow \end{array}$
 Rua (*i) minnassa $[_{TP[-FIN]}$ byasa $[_{INT}$ duappak $]$ na-rokko' sangallo],
 Once 3ABS clear usually two packs 3ERG-smoke a day
 'It was once clear that he usually smoked two packs a day,'

Given that τ^0 must agree with the element in the high subject position, we can thus be sure that the high subject position, in this context, is either empty or filled by an expletive that fails to trigger the ordinary pattern of third-person agreement. And as the high subject position strictly attempts to attract the element that raises into the low subject position, we can deduce that the same must be true of the matrix low subject position as well: SPEC,voiceP must be empty (72a) or contain an expletive that fails to agree (72b).

(72) *Low Subject Position: Two Possibilities in the Matrix Clause*

a. EMPTY SPEC,voiceP:

$\begin{array}{c} \vdots \\ \downarrow \end{array}$
 $[_{TP} \tau^0 [_{ASPP} \text{ — } \dots [_{voiceP} \text{ — } \dots [_{ASPP} \text{ — } \dots [_{voiceP} QP_{WEAK} \dots [_{VP} QP_{WEAK}]]]]]]]$

b. SPECIAL EXPLETIVE:

$\begin{array}{c} \vdots \text{X} \downarrow \downarrow \downarrow \downarrow \downarrow \downarrow \\ \downarrow \end{array}$
 $[_{TP} \tau^0 [_{ASPP} EXPL \dots [_{voiceP} EXPL \dots [_{ASPP} EXPL \dots [_{voiceP} QP_{WEAK} [_{VP} QP_{WEAK}]]]]]]]$

It is against this backdrop that we turn to the following fact: in other contexts there is clear evidence that expletives are inserted into SPEC,voiceP. In weather verb constructions, Mandar shows a syntax that is familiar and notorious across the subfamily (Kaufman, 2008): the clauses built around these verbs must host third-person absolutive agreement.

(73) *Weather Verb Clauses: Third-Person Absolutive Agreement*

$\begin{array}{c} \vdots \\ \downarrow \end{array}$
 Urang i [pro]
 rain 3ABS it
 'It's raining.'

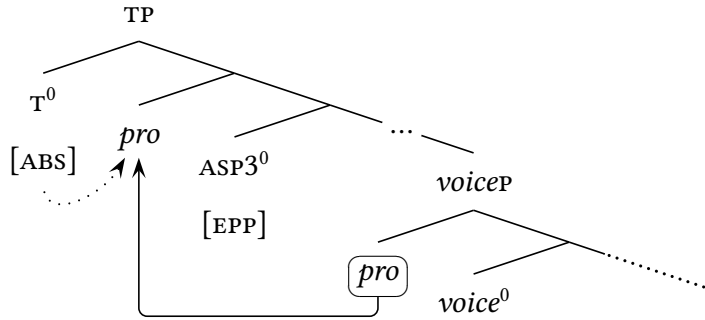
The same pattern emerges in all clauses that lack nominal arguments in the voiceP: for instance, those built around adjectival predicates that select complement cps (74a). It can also be seen in clauses where cps are selected by transitive verbs, like issang 'know' (74b).

(74) *VoicePs without Absolutives: Third-Person Abslutive Agreement*

- a. Minnassa i [*pro*] [_{CP} mua' urang i [*pro*]].
 clear 3ABS it that rain 3ABS it
 'It's clear that it's raining.'
- b. U-issang i [*pro*] [_{CP} mua' minnassa i [*pro*]].
 1ERG-know 3ABS it that clear 3ABS it
 'I know that it's clear.'

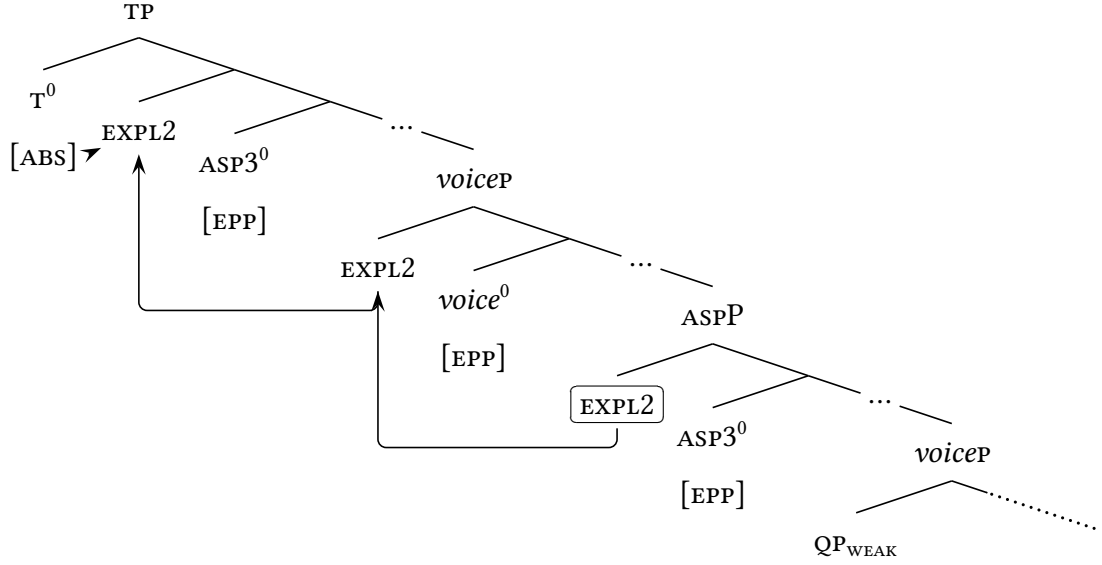
When the *voiceP* contains nothing that can be attracted to *SPEC,voiceP*, then, I propose that the low subject position is filled by a null pronominal expletive. This is one that can successfully interact with the higher syntax of the middle field, and as a result, it controls agreement on τ^0 —raising, by hypothesis, through the higher subject position on the way.

(75) *Low Subject Position: Pronominal Expletives*



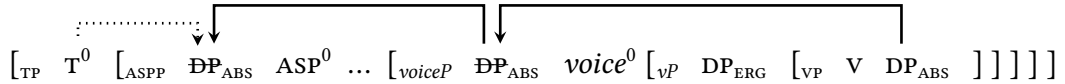
This analytical step provides the linchpin of our case for expletive insertion into the high subject position. In the raising complements where the low subject position is filled by a weak *QP*, we have seen that absolutive agreement is forced to disappear in the matrix clause. This fact suggests that the matrix clause cannot contain the type of expletive that is inserted directly into *SPEC,voiceP*. But given that the low subject position demonstrably forces the insertion of these expletives when it fails to attract anything else, it stands to reason that it must be filled in this context by some other type of element that fails to control the usual pattern of agreement on τ^0 . Given that there is no plausible candidate for attraction in the *voiceP*, this must be one that originates in the lower clause. On the language-internal hypothesis that *QPs* always move in a manner that is overt, moreover, it cannot be the embedded weak *QP*. As a result, I argue that the matrix low subject position must be filled by a second type of expletive that is drawn up from the high subject position of the embedded clause. I will temporarily use the label *EXPL2* to represent this second type of expletive, which is inserted in that position whenever it fails to attract a weak *QP*.

(76) *High Subject Position: Locative Expletives*



This final conclusion allows us to reinforce and extend the central results of the second half of our investigation. The contrast between two types of null element in SPEC, *voiceP* in the raising contexts above suggests that ASP^0 must force the introduction of expletives into its specifier when it cannot attract the elements that raise to the low subject position. This property, in turn, suggests that ASP^0 must enforce a purely formal requirement that its specifier be filled—reinforcing the case we built in Section 4 from the facts of strong QPs. And with this second line of support in place, we can now double down on the argument that the same position must also draw up ordinary absolutive DPs—yielding the systematic sequence of covert movement through the two interlocking systems of subjecthood in (77).

(77) *Two Steps to the Syntax of Subjecthood*



In the Austronesian context, finally, the case for expletives leads to one further result. Across the region, there is a strand of work that recasts the absolutive DP as a type of $\bar{A}$ -topic and links its movement to the left-peripheral syntax of topicalization (Pearson, 2005; Chen, 2017). The facts of binding and case raise challenges for this view across the region, as does the fact that absolutive DPs generally lack the discourse properties of topics (e.g. in Tagalog: Kroeger 1993). But in Mandarin, we can now mount a new argument against this view: if the position that draws up the absolutive DP can force the insertion of semantically vacuous expletives, it cannot be bound up with the $\bar{A}$ -syntax of topicality.

5.3 Deriving the Pattern of Insertion

With this vision of clause structure in place, we can wrap up our investigation with a turn to the finer properties of the high subject position—and in particular, three questions that emerge when the link between the low and high subject positions breaks down.

- (i) when the high subject position hosts EXPL2, why does absolutive agreement disappear?
- (ii) when the high subject position hosts EXPL2, how are weak QPs assigned abstract Case?
- (iii) when weak QPs raise to SPEC, *voice*⁰, why must the high subject position host EXPL2?

The natural path through these puzzles runs through a relatively uncharted empirical terrain, and this is one that emerges in clauses built around two verb-like elements: the copula *ia* and the existential *diang*. The copula *ia* always surfaces before its arguments, as if it raised to a head like *voice*⁰, and the clauses built around it show the usual pattern of absolutive agreement whenever the apparent subject of the copular clause is definite (78a). But this agreement disappears, in a telltale fashion, in the types of copular clauses whose apparent subjects are indefinite: for instance, in characterizing statements like (78b).

(78) *Copular Clauses: Indefinites → ✗Agreement*

- a. Ia **di** [SUBJECT? *pro*] gau'-na: mallaga lopi, ma'ala panginrangang.
 is JUST.3ABS it habit-3GEN dock boat take debt
 'It's just his habit: dock his boat, take on debt.' Muthalib & Sangi 1991, 379
- b. Ia ___/*i [SUBJECT? *mesa koin*] mesa poin.
 is /3ABS one coin one point
 'One coin is one point.'

We see the same effect with a wider class of indefinites in the clauses built around the existential *diang*: when the only nominal is indefinite, absolutive agreement disappears.

(79) *Existential Clauses: Indefinites → ✗Agreement*

- Diang ___/*i [SUBJECT? *mesa koin / koin / koi-koin / doi'*] di aya di meja.
 EXIST /3ABS one coin coin coins money on top on table
 'There's one coin/a coin/coins/money on the table.'

These facts show that the suppression of absolutive agreement is keyed to definiteness: descriptively speaking, τ^0 fails to appear in clauses that lack a definite target of agreement. The syntax beneath this system, then, must be sensitive to a distinction between definite

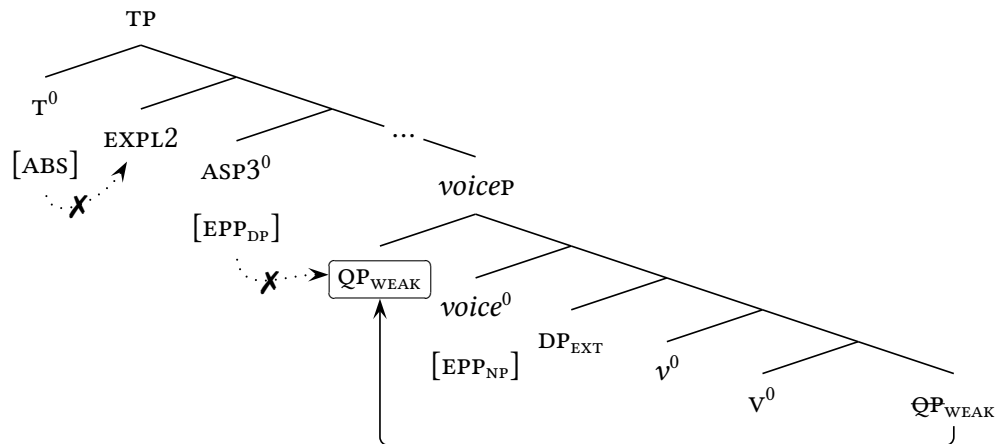
and indefinite nominals—one instantiated in the syntax, I will assume, as a divide between DPs and NPs. This is a division that must generally be covert in Mandar (though it is drawn overtly in most languages of the South Sulawesi subfamily), as the language lacks a visible definite article and requires contextually unique but discourse-new nominals to surface bare (80a). But it is one that is referenced by many further systems in the language: for instance, the antipassive construction always requires the INT and GOAL to surface bare and receive indefinite interpretations, as if it requires those arguments to be NPs (80b).

(80) *Definiteness: Covert Syntactic Distinction*

- a. U-ita i [_{DP} Ø_D **bulang**].
 1ERG-see 3ABS the moon
 ‘I saw the moon.’
- b. Wattu’u di aya di Pluto dionging, **ma’-ita** a’ [_{NP} **bulang**].
 When I was up on Pluto the other day, ANTIP-see 1ABS moon
 ‘When I was up on Pluto the other day, I saw a moon.’

This analytical step allows us to understand the disappearance of agreement as follows: whenever an indefinite raises to the low subject position (or its counterpart, if any exists, in the clauses built around the copula and the existential), it is structurally too small to be attracted further into the middle field. The head ASP^0 , in other words, must only ever attract the class of nominals that project up to or past the level of DP (thus accepting DPs and strong QPs but rejecting NPs and weak QPs). This property separates it from $voice^0$, which freely attracts nominals of this second and smaller size—and in the cases where $voice^0$ pulls up a nominal of this second type, the high subject position must be filled with EXPL2. It is the presence of this element that forces the ensuing loss of agreement in T^0 .

(81) *Indefinites: Rejected by the High Subject Position*



6 Conclusion

We thus conclude of our study of Mandar with the understanding that the vsOD order of the language masks a rich and relatively ordinary syntax of subjecthood: one on which the absolutive DP is systematically raised to a low subject position at the edge of the *voiceP* and is then canonically drawn up to a second high subject position within the middle field. These steps of movement are driven by the formal requirement that particular specifiers be filled along the clausal spine, and their force is to ferry a single nominal—the absolutive—to a position where it ultimately receives the highest clause-internal source of abstract Case. It is this set of properties that establishes the absolutive DP as a subject, in the familiar generative sense, and it is the interaction of this system with the network of alternations that guide Case-licensing in the extended VP that yields the Austronesian system of voice.

The wider perspective that emerges from this research is one that draws two puzzles into focus for future work. The first of these lies with the distinction between movements that are overt and covert. It is both familiar and expected, on the copy-theoretic approach (Chomsky, 1993), that A-movement should allow its targets to be spelled out in their base positions (Potsdam & Polinsky, 2012). But it is a curious fact that the preference for covert A-movement should be so persistent in Mandar (and seemingly in many other languages of the region)—and stranger still that it should be suspended in Mandar for the class of QPs. The systems that lie beneath these preferences are at present not well understood (though see Sabbagh 2014 for an attempt to link an analogous pattern in Tagalog to the prosody), and as a result, they remain a clear target and priority for future work across the region.

The second mystery lies with the exact height of the low subject position. The facts of linear order provide relatively clear evidence that the Mandar absolutive DP must raise to a position that falls between the extended VP and the middle field: in our terms, SPEC,*voiceP*. Within the frameworks that take the extended VP to form a cyclic domain of computation, this is one that can be identified as the edge of the clause-internal phase (Chomsky, 2001). This abstract position is one that high absolutive DPs have long been held to pass through on primarily theory-internal grounds—and more particularly, in light of the view that DPs must raise to the edge to be accessible to the middle-field heads that they rely on for Case (Aldridge, 2004; Coon *et al.*, 2014). This is a vision that has immediate implications for the wider theory of subjecthood, as it seems to require all types of subjects to pass through this edge, and it has been challenged by the strands of work that take phases to be porous to AGREE (Bošković, 2007) or reject the existence of a *voiceP*-phase (Keine 2020). It is thus a telling fact that in Mandar it is borne out—and it remains to be seen what this will reveal.

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